

USER MANUAL (PORTFOLIO SAMPLE)

Jira

A User Manual for Agile Teams

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Audience	Team members new to Jira on an Agile team — developers, product owners, and technical writers

1. About This Manual

This manual introduces Jira Software to team members working on an Agile team — developers, product owners, and technical writers — who are new to the tool. It covers project setup, boards, the backlog/sprint workflow, searching with JQL, reports, and where documentation fits into a Jira-tracked project.

Jira is Atlassian's issue-tracking and Agile project management tool. It's the specific software many teams use to put Scrum or Kanban into practice — pair this manual with a general Agile methodology reference if you're also new to Agile concepts themselves, not just the tool.

2. Jira Basics

Jira organizes work into projects, and work within a project into issues (sometimes called work items) — the individual units of trackable work. Atlassian's product family includes Jira Software (Agile/Scrum/Kanban for delivery teams), Jira Service Management (helpdesk/ITSM), and Jira Work Management (general business project tracking). This manual focuses on Jira Software.

TIP: Jira projects come in two flavors: team-managed (simpler, configured by the team itself) and company-managed (more configuration options, typically administered centrally). Some menu paths and settings differ between them — confirm which type your project uses if a step doesn't match what you see.

3. Work Item Types

Work items follow a hierarchy, from large bodies of work down to granular tracked tasks.

Item Type	What It's For
Epic	A large body of work spanning multiple sprints, broken down into stories or tasks.
Story	A feature or requirement described from the user's perspective, sized to fit within a sprint.
Task	A piece of work that isn't naturally a user-facing story — technical work, documentation, research.
Bug	A defect in existing functionality that needs to be fixed.
Sub-task	A smaller unit of work broken out from a story, task, or bug for finer-grained tracking.

4. Boards: Scrum vs. Kanban

A board is a visual, filtered view of your project's issues. Jira offers two board types, matching the two most common Agile frameworks.

	Scrum Board	Kanban Board
Work organized by	Fixed-length sprints	Continuous flow, no fixed iteration
Backlog	Separate from the board; items pulled in during sprint planning	Often the board's first column itself
Best suited for	Teams delivering in regular, predictable cycles	Support, maintenance, or continuous-delivery work
Key reports	Burndown chart, velocity chart, sprint report	Cumulative flow diagram, control chart, cycle time

5. Setting Up a Project

1. **Create the project.** From the Jira home screen, select Create project, choose Scrum or Kanban as the template, and select team-managed or company-managed.
2. **Name and key the project.** Give the project a clear name and confirm its project key (used as the prefix for issue IDs, e.g., DOCS-123).
3. **Configure issue types.** Confirm which issue types (Epic, Story, Task, Bug, Sub-task) are enabled for the project and adjust if your team needs a different set.
4. **Set up the workflow.** Review the default workflow (the statuses an issue moves through, e.g., To Do → In Progress → In Review → Done) and customize it to match your team's actual process.
5. **Invite team members.** Add team members to the project with appropriate roles/permissions.
6. **Create the first backlog items.** Add a starter set of epics and stories to the backlog so the team has something to plan against.

6. Working the Backlog and Sprints (Scrum)

7. **Refine the backlog.** Regularly review upcoming backlog items with the team: clarify requirements, add estimates, and break down large items.

8. **Prioritize.** Keep the backlog ordered top-to-bottom by priority — drag-and-drop reordering reflects what the team should pull next.
9. **Plan the sprint.** During sprint planning, select a sprint duration and drag backlog items into the sprint until the team's capacity is met, then start the sprint.
10. **Work the board.** As work progresses, move issues across the board's columns to reflect their actual status — the board should mirror reality, not the other way around.
11. **Track daily.** Use the board during daily standup to review what's in progress, what's blocked, and what's left.
12. **Complete the sprint.** At sprint end, complete the sprint in Jira; incomplete issues are returned to the backlog or moved to the next sprint per your team's convention.

7. Working a Kanban Board

- Add new work directly to the board's backlog column or a dedicated backlog view, depending on configuration.
- Set work-in-progress (WIP) limits on columns to prevent the team from starting more than it can finish.
- Pull the next-highest-priority item into progress as capacity opens up, rather than batch-assigning work.
- Use the cumulative flow diagram to spot where work is piling up (a widening band in one column signals a bottleneck).

8. Searching with JQL

Jira Query Language (JQL) lets you search issues with precision beyond the basic search and filter UI. Most saved filters, board configurations, and dashboards are ultimately built on JQL underneath.

```
project = "DOCS" AND status = "In Progress" AND assignee = currentUser()  
issuetype = Bug AND priority = High AND created >= -7d  
sprint in openSprints() AND labels = "needs-docs"
```

TIP: Use the JQL autocomplete in the search bar — it suggests valid field names, operators, and values as you type, which catches most typos before you run the query.

9. Reports

- Burndown chart (Scrum): tracks remaining work against time within a sprint — a flat or rising line signals the sprint is falling behind.
- Velocity chart (Scrum): shows completed work per sprint over time, used to forecast future sprint capacity.
- Cumulative flow diagram (Kanban): shows issue counts per status over time, useful for spotting bottlenecks.
- Control chart (Kanban): shows how long issues take to move through the workflow (cycle time).

10. Where Documentation Fits

Technical writers working alongside a Jira-tracked team typically track their own work the same way the rest of the team does, rather than off to the side in a separate system.

- Create documentation tasks as their own issues (often linked to the feature story they document), so writing work is visible in sprint planning.

- Use issue links (e.g., “documents” / “is documented by”) to connect a documentation task to the feature it covers.
- Add a “needs-docs” or similar label to features that require documentation, and use it in board filters or JQL to track what's outstanding.
- If your organization also uses Confluence, link the Jira issue to the Confluence page tracking the actual draft, so status and content stay connected.

11. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Probable Cause	Corrective Action
Can't find an issue I know exists	Filtered view, wrong project selected, or issue is in a different board's backlog	Clear active filters/quick filters; search by issue key or use basic search; confirm you're viewing the correct project.
Can't start a sprint	Sprint start is a permission-gated action, or a sprint is already active	Confirm you have the required project role/permission; check whether another sprint is already in progress for that board.
Issue doesn't appear on the board after being created	Issue's status doesn't map to any column on this board, or it's filtered out by a board filter	Check the board's configured workflow-to-column mapping; review any saved JQL filter applied to the board.
Story points field is missing	Story points estimation isn't enabled for this project, or the field isn't on the issue's screen	Confirm the project is Scrum-type with estimation enabled; check the issue type's field configuration (company-managed projects) or project settings (team-managed).
Burndown chart looks wrong or flat	Estimates weren't set before the sprint started, or scope changed significantly mid-sprint	Ensure estimates are entered during backlog refinement, before sprint start, for the chart to reflect real progress.
JQL search returns no results despite matching issues	Field name typo, wrong operator, or issue doesn't actually match the value expected	Use the JQL autocomplete suggestions to confirm field names; test the query one clause at a time.

12. Revision History

Rev.	Date	Author	Description of Change
01	2026-07-31	M. Langley, Tech. Writer	Initial release covering project setup, boards, backlog/sprint workflow, JQL basics, reports, and troubleshooting.